# Swimming Champion Archie Goodburn to Deliver Rugby Match Ball in Front of 60,000 Fans

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Champion swimmer Archie Goodburn is swapping the pool for a rugby stadium just for one very special moment. On Sunday, November 15, the 25-year-old from Edinburgh will deliver the match ball for Scotland's Nations Championship game against Australia at Murrayfield, in front of more than 60,000 fans.

Goodburn is a British champion and a European bronze medallist, and he holds the Scottish record for the 50-metre **breaststroke**. But lately he has been racing for something bigger than medals. In 2024 he was diagnosed with a rare brain tumour called an **oligodendroglioma**. After surgery, he fought his way back to competitive swimming and began campaigning for better brain cancer treatment and research.

His campaign has carried him a long way. In recent weeks, he has taken it to Prime Minister Andy Burnham and to Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney. The campaign aims to **bolster** treatment and research for brain cancer.

Being guest of honour at Murrayfield is a homecoming, too. Goodburn once played rugby himself, at **blindside flanker** for Stewart's-Melville College, before concentrating on swimming. Big crowds do not scare him either: at age 12 he sang a solo, 'What a Wonderful World,' in front of 10,000 people on the castle **esplanade** for the Edinburgh Military Tattoo.

'This means the absolute world to me,' he said.

Fans at the match will also be able to donate to two charities helping people with brain cancer: Brain Tumour Research and the Astro Brain Tumour Fund.

'Things are beginning to move,' Goodburn said, 'and this kind of initiative can make a difference.'

## Word Treasure

**oligodendroglioma** -- A rare kind of brain tumour, the illness Goodburn was diagnosed with.

**breaststroke** -- A swimming stroke in which the arms and legs move together in a frog-like way.

**blindside flanker** -- A playing position in a rugby team, in the group of forwards.

**esplanade** -- A wide, flat open area, here the space in front of the castle.

**bolster** -- To support something and make it stronger.

## Background you need

Delivering the match ball is an honour at big rugby games: a special guest carries the ball onto the pitch before kick-off, in front of the whole crowd.

Murrayfield, in Edinburgh, is the home stadium of Scotland's national rugby team.

A brain tumour is a growth of cells inside the brain. Some kinds can be removed with surgery, but treatment is difficult, which is why people who have had the illness often campaign for better treatment and more research.

Goodburn's story mixes both of his sports: he played rugby at school before concentrating on swimming, so appearing at Murrayfield brings the two together.

## Break it down

**LEAD:** Champion swimmer Archie Goodburn will deliver the match ball for Scotland's Nations Championship game against Australia at Murrayfield on Sunday, November 15

**KEY EVENT:** Goodburn appears as guest of honour in front of more than 60,000 fans

+- WHO: Archie Goodburn, 25, from Edinburgh -- British champion, European bronze medallist and Scottish record holder for the 50-metre breaststroke

+- WHY: Diagnosed in 2024 with a rare brain tumour, an oligodendroglioma, he returned to competitive swimming after surgery and began campaigning for better brain cancer treatment and research

+- CAMPAIGN: He has taken the campaign to Prime Minister Andy Burnham and Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney; fans at the match can donate to Brain Tumour Research and the Astro Brain Tumour Fund

**EVIDENCE:** Goodburn once played rugby at blindside flanker for Stewart's-Melville College and sang a solo in front of 10,000 people on the castle esplanade at age 12

**OPEN QUESTION:** Whether moments like this will help the campaign make a difference -- Goodburn says things are beginning to move

## Why it matters

Goodburn's appearance links a huge sporting crowd to brain cancer research, a cause that affects patients and families, including young people. It also shows how an athlete can use sporting fame to push for better treatment for others.

## Test what you remember

**1. What will Archie Goodburn do at Murrayfield on November 15?**

(A) Deliver the match ball before Scotland's game against Australia
(B) Race in a 50-metre breaststroke final
(C) Sing a solo at the Edinburgh Military Tattoo
(D) Play at blindside flanker for Scotland

**2. What Scottish record does Goodburn hold?**

(A) The 50-metre breaststroke record
(B) The 200-metre backstroke record
(C) The 50-metre butterfly record
(D) The 100-metre freestyle record

**3. What was Goodburn diagnosed with in 2024?**

(A) A lung illness
(B) A rare brain tumour called an oligodendroglioma
(C) A heart condition
(D) A knee injury

**4. Which two leaders has he taken his campaign to in recent weeks?**

(A) Prime Minister Andy Burnham and Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney
(B) John Swinney and the director of the Edinburgh Military Tattoo
(C) Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney, and the captain of Australia's rugby team
(D) Andy Burnham and Goodburn's former rugby coach

**5. Where did Goodburn sing a solo at age 12?**

(A) At Stewart's-Melville College
(B) On the castle esplanade, for the Edinburgh Military Tattoo
(C) At a swimming championship in front of 60,000 fans
(D) At Murrayfield before a rugby match

**6. Which charities can fans donate to at the match?**

(A) Two cancer charities run by the Scottish rugby team
(B) Brain Tumour Research and the Astro Brain Tumour Fund
(C) Brain Tumour Research and the Murrayfield Trust
(D) The Astro Brain Tumour Fund and Scotland's national swimming charities

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: B 6: B

## Questions to think about

1. **Archie Goodburn: He said the honour means the absolute world to him, and that things are beginning to move, so this kind of initiative can make a difference.**

2. **Goodburn's campaign: The campaign aims to bolster treatment and research for brain cancer and has been taken to Prime Minister Andy Burnham and Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney.**

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**